

Inherited Housing and Household Investment: Evidence from Germany and Spain

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Abstract

Intergenerational transfers constitute an increasingly important component of aggregate private wealth in Europe (Alvaredo et al. 2017). However, little is known about how households use inherited assets once transfers occur. This is particularly relevant for real estate, as dwindling housing supply and stringent land regulations are making homeownership increasingly unaffordable, particularly for low-wealth households.

Using the longitudinal component of the ECB's Household Finance and Consumption Survey (HFCS), this paper examines within-household investment responses to real estate inheritance in Germany and Spain.

The findings reveal that households respond differently according to the underlying structure of the housing market. In Germany, where speculative housing investment has historically been less pronounced than in Spain, households are more likely to use inherited dwellings as collateral to finance additional property purchases. In contrast, Spanish households are more likely to derive persistent rental income from inherited property. The results offer new insights into the wealth-accumulating mechanisms associated with the intergenerational transmission of real estate, and contribute to ongoing debates about housing affordability and wealth inequality.

Keywords: Bequests, Household Assets, Wealth, Mortgages, Investment Decisions

JEL Classification: D14 , G51

1 Introduction

Recent projections estimate that by 2030, approximately \$10.6 trillion will be transferred across generations in the U.S., \$3.5 trillion in Europe, and \$2.8 trillion in Asia¹. A substantial share of these transfers is expected to take the form of real estate, bringing about an unprecedented level of change to inheriting households' balance sheets.

Nevertheless, little is known about how households use inherited property, as the literature has paid relatively less attention to the asset composition of inheritance. This is particularly relevant in a context where property holdings are both frequently inherited (Arrondel et al. 2014) and unevenly distributed (Nolan et al. 2021), raising concerns regarding the persistence of asset disadvantages across generations.

A large body of literature shows that homeownership is associated with higher long-run wealth accumulation relative to renting. For instance, Di et al. (2007) document that homeowners accumulate significantly more wealth than comparable renters, even during periods when alternative investments other than housing performed well and rents grew slowly. Similarly, Turner and Luea (2009) estimate that each additional year of homeownership increases net wealth by approximately \$13,700 on average.

Other studies emphasize the role of parental housing wealth in driving children's homeownership rates. For example, Mulder et al. (2015) show that growing up in a homeowner household significantly increases the likelihood of becoming a homeowner, particularly in contexts where house prices are high. Likewise, Blanden et al. (2023) find a steady rise over time in the intergenerational persistence of homeownership, while Daysal et al. (2023) demonstrate that parental housing wealth gains during childhood have large causal effects on children's adult wealth.

While this literature establishes that housing wealth is transmitted intergenerationally, much less is known about how households actively respond to inherited property once transfers occur. This is especially important today, as rising house prices and asset concentration are making homeownership increasingly unaffordable, particularly for young and low-wealth households (Licchetta et al. 2025).

This paper fills this gap by studying the wealth-generating mechanisms associated with real estate inheritance in two European countries, namely, Germany and Spain. Using data from the ECB's Household Finance and Consumption Survey (HFCS), I construct a panel dataset from the subset of households observed in all survey waves (2010, 2014, 2017, and 2020), and ask two main questions: *Does inheriting real estate open new investment opportunities?* and *How do these effects vary over time?*

To answer these questions, I exploit the detailed information collected in the interviews on the type of assets received at each wave. While the HFCS reports any bequests received during a person's lifetime, I follow Mathä et al. (2017) and construct a *time-since-receipt* measure that accounts for time heterogeneity, thereby isolating inheritance movements over time. Moreover, to identify asset-specific effects, I focus on households that inherit only one type of asset during the observation period, allowing for a clean comparison of asset-specific estimates.

¹Vanguard: The Great Wealth Transfer. <https://d1e00ek4ebabms.cloudfront.net/production/uploaded-files/The%20Great%20Wealth%20Transfer-f910ae70-5ab7-4ba4-a3f7-e86377ecc56d.pdf>. Accessed 02 March 2025.

The analysis reveals novel insights into household financial decisions. First, the impact of property transfers strongly depends on the underlying structure of the housing market. In Germany, where the homeownership rate is the lowest in Europe (Kofner 2014; Kaas et al. 2021), households inheriting a dwelling leverage the asset as collateral to purchase additional real estate, contributing to further wealth accumulation among already asset-rich families. By contrast, in Spain, where the homeownership rate is among the highest in Europe (Nasarre-Aznar and Molina-Roig 2017; Guinea et al. 2023), inherited property is less likely to relax binding collateral constraints. Instead, households convert inherited property into rental income streams. The effects are persistent in the long term, reinforcing existing disparities between haves and have-nots.

This paper makes three main contributions. First, it provides the first empirical evidence on the mechanisms through which real estate inheritance affects household investment decisions. In doing so, it bridges the literature on intergenerational transfers and housing wealth. While previous studies have focused primarily on the impact of bequests on wealth inequality (Elinder et al. 2018; Keister et al. 2019; Palomino et al. 2022; Horioka 2024), less consideration has been given to the channels driving these effects. This omission is particularly relevant given that real assets represent the major mechanism of wealth accumulation in most OECD countries (OECD 2020). By showing that property transfers produce different effects according to the institutional context under analysis, this paper provides policy-relevant findings that can help to mitigate the negative consequences associated with the transmission of asset disadvantages across generations.

Second, the results resonate with studies emphasizing the collateral role of housing equity in relaxing credit constraints and shaping household financial decisions (Mian et al. 2013; Mian and Sufi 2014; Aladangady 2017). By isolating the asset composition of inheritance, the analysis shows that inheriting real estate, much like increases in house prices, may stimulate new investments through collateral effects. While heirs may have expectations regarding future transfers based on parental wealth, the economic implications materialize only once ownership rights are transferred. Accordingly, inherited property can be pledged as collateral only after the transfer occurs, making the realized inheritance event the relevant moment for households' balance sheet adjustments.

Finally, the paper builds on existing HFCS-based studies (see, among others, Korom 2016; Humer et al. 2017; Fessler and Schürz 2018b; Spiteri and Von Brockdorff 2023) by providing the first longitudinal analysis of the dataset. By employing linear fixed-effects models, the analysis removes time-invariant unobserved heterogeneity from the observed outcomes and offers a new within-household perspective to the inheritance-wealth relationship. At the same time, as no specific panel weights are available, the HFCS panel is best regarded as experimental (Household Finance and Consumption Network 2023), and the findings should be interpreted with caution in terms of national representativeness. Nevertheless, the results provide original insights into how inheritance shapes households' investment decisions, and show that what households inherit matters at least as much as whether they inherit.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 reviews the related literature and develops the testable hypotheses. Section 3 describes the data and empirical strategy. Section 4 presents the results, and Section 5 concludes with a summary of the findings and main contributions to the literature.

2 Literature Review

Intergenerational transfers have become an increasingly important determinant of household wealth accumulation in advanced economies. Recent research shows that the share of inherited wealth relative to total wealth has followed a U-shaped trajectory, reversing the low levels seen in the mid-20th century (Piketty and Zucman 2014). For instance, France, Germany, and the UK saw the ratio drop under 40% around 1970–1980, then increase substantially to about 50–60% of total wealth by 2010 (Alvaredo et al. 2017).

These trends spurred a growing body of research to capture their effect on wealth accumulation, with results varying according to the methodology used. For example, using Norwegian administrative registers, Black et al. (2020, 2024) find that inheritances play only a limited role in lifetime accumulation of resources, as their size is relatively small compared to other sources of wealth, such as income. Similarly, Karagiannaki (2017) leverages the British Household Panel Survey to assess their effect on household wealth accumulation and inequality, revealing that inheritances were too small to substantially affect overall wealth inequality, especially compared to housing wealth dynamics. Conversely, Palomino et al. (2022) build a counterfactual wealth distribution across four OECD countries to quantify how much of observed wealth inequality is associated with intergenerational transfers and family background. The authors show that inheritances matter more than family background, and account for up to 36% of overall wealth inequality².

As shown by Boserup et al. (2016), the measure used to evaluate wealth inequality can profoundly impact the results of the analysis. By exploiting Danish population and wealth registers, the authors document that average bequest increases recipients' wealth by roughly 36%. In addition, the authors demonstrate that wealth transfers stretch the wealth distribution to the right, as gains are larger in absolute levels toward the top. At the same time, top wealth shares fall, because middle and lower parts of the distribution gain proportionally more relative to their baseline wealth. This finding suggests that bequests increase absolute levels of inequality while decreasing relative inequality, and is confirmed in a number of other studies (Wolff and Gittleman 2011; Crawford and Hood 2016; Elinder et al. 2018).

Nevertheless, Nekoei and Seim (2023) show that this effect is short-lived and tends to disappear within about 10 years after the inheritance receipt. The authors argue that, while the average heir depletes most of the inheritance on consumption, richer heirs earn high rates of return on the transfer, fully reversing the equalizing effect. These findings highlight diverging rates of accumulation along the wealth distribution,

²For other studies documenting a negative impact of wealth transfers on wealth inequality, please refer to Feiveson and Sabelhaus (2018a); Adermon et al. (2018); Keister et al. (2019); Horioka (2024).

and are consistently found in other strands of literature (Fagereng et al. 2020; Bach et al. 2020; Xavier 2021; Balloch and Richers 2023).

This heterogeneity resonates with the focus of this paper, where the asset composition of inheritance is analyzed to identify micro-mechanisms that lead to compounding rates of wealth accumulation. In this regard, housing assets are especially relevant since they represent more than half of the total assets of households in the middle three quintiles of the wealth distribution (OECD 2021). In addition, as noted by Ioannides and Ngai (2025), housing can perpetuate inequality by enabling owners to use it as collateral for other investments or to obtain higher returns to human capital investments. This is particularly relevant because real estate holdings are closely tied to intergenerational transmission of wealth (Arrondel et al. 2014), and transfer wealth is more unequally distributed than non-transfer wealth and total wealth (Nolan et al. 2021; Morelli et al. 2021), threatening to widen the gap between asset-rich and asset-poor families.

The positive role of owning a house on wealth accumulation is broadly acknowledged in the literature³. For instance, Rognlie (2015) disputes the *accumulation view* of Piketty (2014), according to which the increase of capital’s income share in advanced economies is due to higher saving and a shift of aggregate income from workers to those who own capital. Instead, Rognlie supports a *scarcity view* that follows from limited land availability, the inelasticity of housing supply, and tighter regulation. These factors make residential investment more expensive and rents to rise sharply, increasing the housing’s share of income and contributing to wealth redistribution from renters to homeowners. Therefore, as argued by Ioannides and Ngai (2025), policymakers concerned about inequality should monitor housing costs.

Several studies show that housing prices have been steadily increasing in recent decades. For instance, Knoll et al. (2017) compiled very long-run housing price indices for 14 advanced economies and found that real house prices were essentially flat until around 1950. After that, prices rose strongly in almost all countries, mostly due to general scarcity of land. Similarly, Jordà et al. (2019) estimate for the first time the long-run returns of housing across 16 advanced economies, and reveal that housing delivers similar average real returns than equities (around 7% per year), but with much less volatility.

Taken together, these findings underline the central role of housing as both a consumption unit that provides shelter and a profitable long-term investment, and support the decision to analyze more closely the effect of real estate inheritance in this paper. This choice rests on the assumption that inheriting a property does not merely contribute to household net wealth, but it impacts the overall financial decisions. For instance, exploiting a quasi-exogenous variation in homeownership status of tenants of a Swedish municipality, Sodini et al. (2023) show that house price appreciation causes wealth accumulation by providing collateral and facilitating access to credit. Similarly, Crossley et al. (2024) challenge the traditional narrative linking household borrowing to consumption spending, and argue that house price increases affect net wealth by relaxing credit constraints for additional investments. In other studies, housing value appreciation is associated with job growth and entrepreneurial activity, as households

³See, among others, Killewald and Bryan (2016); Fuller et al. (2020); Wainer and Zabel (2020).

leverage the home equity windfall to open their own businesses (Black et al. 1996; Adelino et al. 2015; Schmalz et al. 2017).

Following this logic, property transfers can be likened to house price appreciation, in that receiving real estate improves credit conditions by enabling borrowing against collateral, which provides the backdrop for the first hypothesis of the paper:

Hypothesis 1: Receiving real estate increases the probability that households borrow against collateral for new investments.

In addition, albeit largely overlooked by the literature on housing and asset-based welfare, secondary property ownership is strongly conducive to new income generation, as households buy (or inherit) property to let (Wind et al. 2020). Single family rentals also represent a large chunk of the housing market in the U.S., where they account for around \$2.3 trillion of total assets, and are highly profitable (Demers and Eisfeldt 2021). According to the authors' estimate, rental yields contribute to roughly half of the average nominal total return (net rental yield + house price appreciation), which stands at about 8.5% per year, and is comparable to equities. This suggests that asset-rich households have an incentive to enter the rental market to generate additional revenue streams, thereby fully exploiting the potential of their property holdings:

Hypothesis 2: Inheriting real estate increases the likelihood that households earn rental income.

The next sections evaluate these hypotheses empirically.

3 Data and Empirical Method

3.1 Data Source

The dataset used for this analysis is the Household Finance and Consumption Survey (HFCS)⁴, a recurring survey conducted approximately every three years that investigates the consumption patterns and financial decision-making of households across Europe. One of the key features of the HFCS is the inclusion of repetitive households, that is, households that are consistently interviewed in all survey waves. This makes it possible to construct a balanced panel to measure the within-household changes in the variables over time. This paper leverages the longitudinal component of two participating countries, namely, Germany and Spain. This choice is based on two reasons: (1) among the four countries providing the necessary data to construct a balanced panel dataset, Germany and Spain have the largest sample, with 1,216 and 809 household-wave observations, respectively⁵; (2) the two countries are located on the opposite ends of the homeownership distribution in Europe.

In fact, according to recent Eurostat data⁶, with around 47% of households owning their home, Germany has the lowest homeownership rate across European countries. By contrast, approximately 74% of Spanish households own the home they live in,

⁴European Central Bank: Household Finance and Consumption Survey (HFCS). https://www.ecb.europa.eu/stats/ecb_surveys/hfcs/html/index.en.html. Accessed 26 April 2026.

⁵Belgium and Cyprus have 335 and 623 household-wave observations each. Italy has also a longitudinal subsample, but it collects inheritance information only for the third wave.

⁶Eurostat: Housing in Europe – 2025 edition. <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/interactive-publications/housing-2025>. Accessed 26 April 2026.

providing a useful setting to analyze the investment responses to property inheritance in differing housing markets.

To date, four survey waves have been conducted by the central banks of participating countries. While the data are centrally coordinated by the European Central Bank (ECB) and rely on a common template for the country questionnaires and output variables, important aspects of survey implementation remain country-specific, and should therefore warrant caution in the cross-country comparability of simple summary statistics (Fessler and Schürz 2013). For instance, relevant time differences in the collection of the survey data exist between the two countries. In Spain, the first wave of data collection was conducted between 2008 and 2009, while in Germany it took place between 2010 and 2011. The second wave was implemented between the end of 2011 and the first half of 2012 in Spain, while in Germany it occurred in 2014, followed by the third wave, which was carried out in 2017 in Germany, and between 2017 and 2018 in Spain. The fourth wave was originally scheduled for 2020 but was disrupted by the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic. As a result, fieldwork ultimately occurred between the end of 2020 and the first half of 2021 in Spain, and between the first half of 2021 and early 2022 in Germany. While these differences matter for descriptive comparability, country-specific regressions mitigate concerns related to differential timing in survey implementation.

An additional source of variation derives from the oversampling strategy adopted by countries to mitigate the well-documented under-reporting of assets affecting surveys, particularly at the top of the wealth distribution (Tiefensee and Grabka 2016; Vermeulen 2016). Specifically, to increase the representation of small subpopulations such as wealthy households, each country implemented ad hoc oversampling strategies that led to diverging sample composition. In this respect, Germany used regional indicators to map households with a bigger income dispersion and a higher taxable income, while Spain leveraged personal taxable wealth to progressively oversample households based on wealth and income tax returns. These strategies effectively captured a sizable share of wealthy respondents, which is also reflected in the composition of this panel dataset. While the HFCS provides cross-sectional weights to re-balance the sample distribution, no dedicated panel weights are available (Household Finance and Consumption Network 2023).

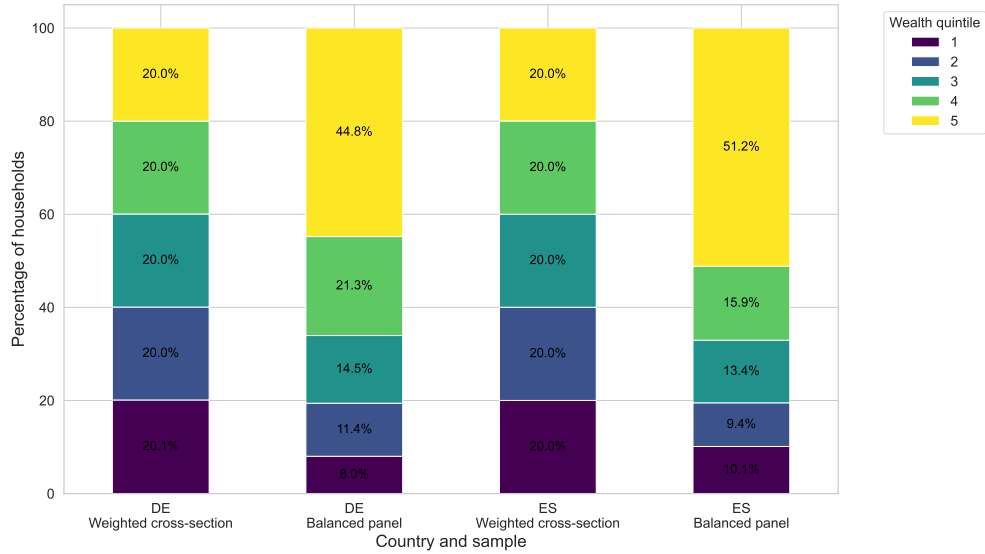


Fig. 1 Households' Wealth Quintiles, by Country and Sample

Figure 1 shows the distributional difference of households by wealth quintile across countries and samples. Compared to the representative cross-section, the balanced panel overrepresents households in the top wealth quintile, particularly in Spain. While the cross-sectional distribution is approximately uniform across quintiles, the panel allocates nearly half of households to the top quintile. This suggests that, unlike other survey studies where the rich population tends to be under-represented (Waltl and Chakraborty 2022), this sample is skewed toward the upper tail of the wealth distribution. Nevertheless, by employing fixed-effects models, the empirical strategy relies on within-household variation, which mitigates concerns related to the over-representation of wealthy households in the balanced panel, as identification does not depend on cross-sectional differences in wealth levels. Accordingly, the analysis should be interpreted as evidence on behavioural responses among relatively wealthy households, rather than as population-representative estimates. Moreover, because inheritance receipt is concentrated among wealthier households (Tiefensee and Westermeier 2016; Nolan et al. 2021), the balanced panel provides substantial within-household variation in transfer exposure, which is particularly useful for studying post-inheritance investment responses.

3.2 Inheritances and Gifts

In the HFCS, bequests are defined as any substantial gift or inheritance received by a member of the household from someone outside the current household. The interviewers record information about the net-of-tax value and receipt year of the three largest inheritances *ever* received by the household. As such, households can report transfers that have occurred many years prior to the interview. To account for

this timing component, I adopt a similar strategy to Mathä et al. (2017), and identify the most recent inheritance event reported at each wave. Then, I subtract it from the interview year to obtain the number of years elapsed since receipt, and create three timing categories: (1) inheritances received 0 to 2 years since the interview, (2) inheritances received since between 3 and 7 years, and (3) transfers received 8 or more years prior to the interview. This strategy successfully isolates within-household changes in inheritance receipt between consecutive interviews, enabling the evaluation of short-run responses to a recent movement in transfer wealth by comparing it with non-inheritors.

In addition, one of the distinguishing features of the HFCS is the collection of the specific asset types received at each wave. Specifically, the HFCS collects information about ten types of transfers: (1) money, (2) dwelling, (3) dwelling use⁷, (4) land, (5) business, (6) securities & shares, (7) valuables, (8) life insurance, (9) vehicles, and (10) other assets. To examine the asset-specific effects of inheritance on household investment, I identify households that reported receiving only one type of asset across the entire observation period. This restriction ensures that the recorded transfer can be attributed solely to that specific asset type, removing confounding factors deriving from reporting more than one asset in the same wave.

Figure 2 shows the distribution of time since receipt among households that inherit only dwellings (top panels) and only land (bottom panels), separately for Germany and Spain. Conditioning on experiencing an inheritance of the given asset, most observed transfers occurred at least eight years prior to the interview, partly reflecting a larger number of years within the 8+ years category. Recent inheritances (0–2 years) account for a smaller share of events, especially in Spain, while Germany exhibits a somewhat more balanced distribution across timing categories. Overall, the figure highlights that meaningful variation exists in the timing of inheritance events, providing the within-household variation needed to estimate timing-specific associations.

⁷ *Dwelling* refers to the transfer of ownership rights over a residential property. By contrast, the category *dwelling use* refers to the transfer of usufruct or similar rights granting the beneficiary the right to occupy or benefit from the property without transferring ownership.

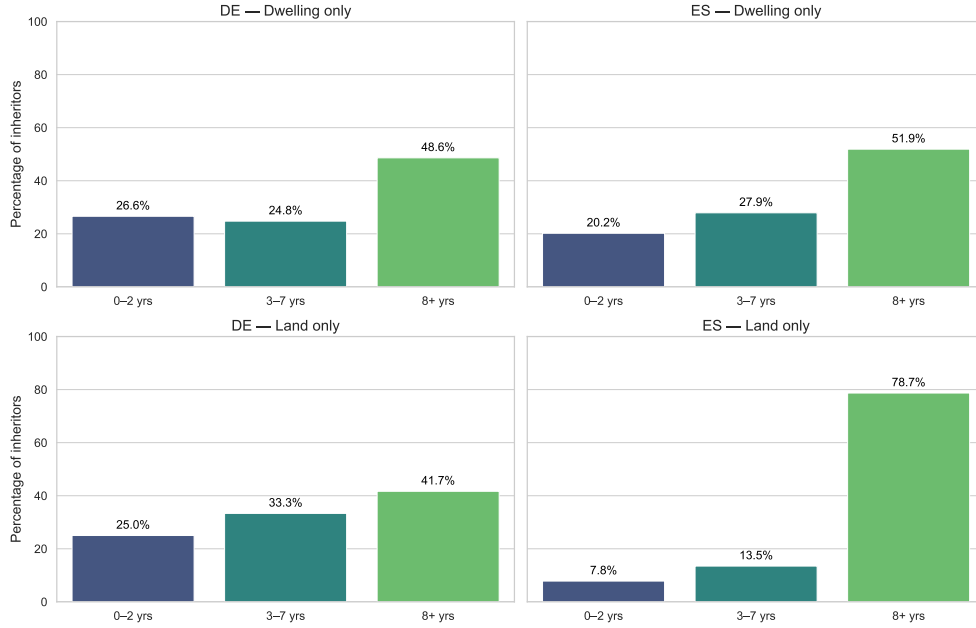


Fig. 2 Distribution of time since receipt among households inheriting only dwellings (top panels) and only land (bottom panels) in Germany (left) and Spain (right). The figure reports the share of inheriting households by timing category (0–2 years, 3–7 years, and 8+ years), conditional on experiencing an inheritance of the given asset.

3.3 Descriptive Statistics

In choosing the set of control variables to be included in the regressions, I follow standard economic reasoning and practices in the household wealth literature (Killewald and Bryan 2016; Karagiannaki 2017; Goodman and Mayer 2018). Table 1 presents summary statistics for all the variables used in the analysis. To mitigate the impact of missingness and item non-response, the values are multiply imputed using Rubin’s rules (Rubin 1987), inferring their imputed value from a set of observable variables that yield five complete datasets.

Panel A reports the dependent variables used in the empirical analysis. In particular, *owns other property* is a binary indicator equal to 1 if the household possesses any properties other than the Household Main Residence (HMR), including real estate outside the survey country. This variable evaluates the incidence of real estate transfers in driving ownership of additional properties across the two countries. The value for the Spanish data is approximately double that of Germany, reflecting cross-country structural differences in real estate holdings (Guinea et al. 2023). Moreover, *mortgage on other property* is a dummy that captures whether the household has, at the time of the interview, any outstanding mortgages or loans using other property as collateral, and serves as a proxy for collateralized borrowing behaviour. Drawing on a larger number of properties, this type of mortgage is slightly more frequent in the Spanish

data than in Germany in absolute terms. However, relative to the number of assets owned, German households reveal a higher propensity to collateralize other property to access credit. This statistic is also reflected in the dummy *mortgage for additional real estate*, which directly captures the residential investment channel hypothesized in this paper. Specifically, the HFCS collects information regarding the purpose behind the mortgage. In this case, *mortgage for additional real estate* is a dummy equal to 1 for households using a mortgage collateralized by other property to purchase additional real estate, thus providing a direct test of the investment response associated with property inheritance. Despite twice as many Spanish households report owning other property as German households, the mean of *mortgage for additional real estate* indicates that German households resort to this type of borrowing more frequently, revealing important descriptive differences in the use of leverage for real estate investment.

Table 1 Descriptive Statistics by Country

Variables	N (DE)	Mean (DE)	N (ES)	Mean (ES)
<i>Panel A. Dependent variables</i>				
Owns other property	4,864	0.328	3,236	0.657
Mortgage on other property	4,864	0.096	3,236	0.132
Mortgage for additional real estate	4,864	0.050	3,225	0.035
Has rental income	4,864	0.254	3,236	0.264
<i>Panel B. Inheritance variables</i>				
Has received inheritance	4,864	0.233	3,236	0.460
Dwelling inheritance	4,864	0.073	3,236	0.115
Land inheritance	4,864	0.010	3,236	0.033
<i>Panel C. Controls</i>				
Wealth quintile	4,864	3.834	3,236	3.886
Total gross income, equalized (€)	4,864	48,585	3,236	40,901
Nr. economically active members	4,864	1.060	3,236	1.203
Nr. dependent children	4,864	0.412	3,236	0.564
Age	4,864	58.709	3,236	59.879
Age squared	4,864	3.663	3,236	3.782
Female	4,864	0.281	3,236	0.289
Married	4,864	0.697	3,236	0.665
Employed	4,864	0.566	3,236	0.514
Tertiary education	4,850	0.528	3,217	0.497

Notes: Means are computed from five multiply imputed datasets using Rubin's rules. Binary variables take value 1 if the condition is satisfied and 0 otherwise. Monetary values are expressed in euros.

In addition, *has rental income* is a binary variable that captures whether the household received income from renting real estate in the last 12 months, and is relevant for evaluating whether households use the property shock to generate additional revenue streams by entering the rental market. The mean value is similar between the two countries, with around 25% of households reporting to have earned income from renting in the last calendar year in both countries.

By contrast, panel B shows the key regressors of interest. The dummy *has received inheritance* collects information on aggregate intergenerational transfers over time. In Spain, the mean is nearly double that of Germany, mirroring patterns observed for

ownership of other property. To isolate the asset-specific effect of property inheritance on household investment, *dwelling inheritance* and *land inheritance* capture households that received exclusively that asset type across the entire observation period. The construction of these variables allows a cleaner attribution of the effect to the specific asset inherited, and serves as the main strategy for isolating asset-specific effects.

Panel C lists the control variables included in the models. *Wealth quintile*, among households, is an ordered categorical variable that controls for initial wealth levels, and ensures that the inheritance effect is not inflated by factors such as differing saving behaviors and accumulation capacity. As discussed in Section 3.1, in both countries the mean leans towards the wealthy segment of the population (fifth quintile), suggesting that the sample estimates reflect behavioral responses to inheritance events of relatively wealthy households, rather than population-wide effects.

Total gross annual household income, equalized by the number of economically active members in the household, controls for household earnings and ability to access credit. The variable is constructed by summing several revenue streams, such as labor wage, income from financial assets and pensions, regular social and private transfers, rental income from real estate, and other sources of income. For the models concerning rental income, total income control is net of rental earnings, so as to avoid misspecification.

The estimates also control for demographic covariates known for being associated with wealth and financial outcomes, such as the *number of economically active members* of the household and the *number of dependent children*, which may correlate with housing demand, mortgage uptake and risk exposure. Additional controls traditionally found in the literature include age, age squared, education, gender, marital status, and labor status (Fessler and Schürz 2018b; Spiteri and Von Brockdorff 2023). Following the UNECE (2011) guidelines, these are defined according to the household reference person’s responses, and may therefore vary over time⁸. More specifically, *married*, *employed*, and *tertiary education* are binary indicators constructed from categorical variables. For instance, *married* equals 1 for individuals in a registered marriage and 0 otherwise, while *employed* equals 1 for employees or self-employed individuals and 0 for all other labour statuses. Lastly, *tertiary education* equals 1 for individuals with tertiary qualifications and 0 for lower education levels. A detailed description of the survey questions and variable definitions is provided in Table A.1 of Appendix A.

3.4 Empirical Methodology

The empirical specification used to evaluate the paper’s hypotheses is described in Equation 1. All models are estimated using household fixed-effects regressions on multiply imputed data, with standard errors clustered at the household level:

$$Y_{it}^a = \sum_{k \in \{0-2, 3-7, 8+\}} \beta_k^a (\text{Inheritance}_{it}^a \times \mathbf{1}\{\text{Time}_{it} = k\}) + \gamma^a X'_{it} + \alpha_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}^a, \quad (1)$$

⁸The reference person is uniquely determined by applying the following sequential criteria: first, a partner in a de facto or registered marriage with dependent children; then, a partner in such a union without dependent children; next, a lone parent with children; if none of these apply, the person with the highest income; and finally, the oldest individual in the household.

where Y_{it} denotes one of the outcome variables of interest, including ownership of additional real estate, mortgage holdings, and rental income, for household i at survey wave t . The specifications are estimated separately for Germany and Spain to account for institutional and market differences across countries. The variable $\text{Inheritance}_{it}^a$ is an indicator equal to one if the household has received asset type a , for $a \in \{\text{dwelling, land}\}$, and zero for never-inheriting households.

In addition, the variable Time_{it} captures the time elapsed since the most recent inheritance (0–2 years, 3–7 years, or 8+ years), measured as the number of years elapsed between the interview year and the most recent inheritance receipt. This enables the evaluation of the differential effect of inheritance at different time horizons.

The control vector X_{it} includes time-varying household characteristics such as income, wealth, household composition, and demographic controls, while household fixed effects (α_i) capture time-invariant unobserved heterogeneity. Lastly, year fixed effects (λ_t) control for macroeconomic shocks common to all households, while ε_{it}^a denotes the residual.

4 Estimation Results

The results are presented as follows. Section 4.1 examines the incidence of intergenerational transfers of real estate on the probability of owning other property than the HMR. Section 4.2 investigates household propensity to leverage the inherited property for additional borrowing, while Section 4.3 evaluates the effect of property transfers on households’ decision to enter the rental market.

4.1 Ownership of Other Property

This section examines whether inheriting real estate contributes to the accumulation of additional property holdings beyond the household main residence. Table 2 introduces the results of the household fixed-effects linear probability models, divided by country, asset received (dwelling or land), and time since inheritance.

The findings reveal substantial cross-country heterogeneity. In Germany, where the average household portfolio is less centered around real estate (Kofner 2014; Guinea et al. 2023), receiving a dwelling significantly increases the probability of owning other property than the HMR mostly in the short term (0 to 2 years after inheritance). The magnitude becomes smaller over time, suggesting a relatively recent reliance on inherited property to shore up asset holdings.

Table 2 Inheritance Timing and Ownership of Other Property: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	0.291*** (0.091)	0.098 (0.094)	0.314*** (0.069)	0.280** (0.141)
Received 3–7 years ago	0.066 (0.074)	0.166 (0.266)	0.360*** (0.066)	0.479*** (0.144)
Received 8+ years ago	0.095* (0.054)	-0.067 (0.055)	0.279*** (0.054)	0.453*** (0.109)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,305	1,042
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household owns property other than its main residence. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses. Full estimates reported in the appendix.
* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

In contrast, property transfers appear to play a more persistent role in shaping households’ real estate portfolios in Spain. In particular, the effect corresponds to an increase of about 29-30 percentage points in the probability of owning additional property upon inheriting a dwelling or land in the 0-2 years time category. The effect is persistent and statistically significant over time, indicating a higher degree of property retention compared to German households. This pattern is consistent with diverging expectations about future property prices and understandings of real assets as a source of wealth accumulation (Nasarre-Aznar and Molina-Roig 2017; Guinea et al. 2023). Two wealth-generating mechanisms associated with housing, such as increased collateral for new investments and rental income, are analyzed in the next sections.

4.2 Collateralized Investments

Home equity gains, such as house price increases, have been found to relax credit constraints and increase household borrowing capacity through collateral (Sodini et al. 2023; Crossley et al. 2024). However, the role of inheritance, and in particular of property transfers, in reshaping households’ balance sheets has received less attention in the literature.

Table 3 presents the results associated with the probability of having a mortgage collateralized by other property than the HMR upon receiving some real estate. Much like house price appreciation, property inheritance may strengthen household balance sheets by increasing collateralizable wealth. Accordingly, households may leverage the recently inherited property for new investments and wealth accumulation.

The findings show divergent uses of inheritance across countries. Specifically, in Germany, the inherited dwelling is quickly leveraged to access new loans, as the probability of having a mortgage collateralized by other property increases by 14 percentage points in the short term. The effect is not statistically different from zero in the medium term (3-7 years after inheritance), while it is marginally significant in the longer term (8 years since inheritance). In contrast, inheriting land does not show comparable results. In addition, the results for Spain are insignificant across all specifications, suggesting less reliance on property transfers to access new borrowing.

Table 3 Inheritance Timing and Mortgages on Other Properties: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	0.140** (0.063)	-0.020 (0.070)	-0.038 (0.062)	-0.096 (0.097)
Received 3–7 years ago	0.063 (0.090)	0.244 (0.216)	0.060 (0.045)	0.105 (0.098)
Received 8+ years ago	0.083* (0.046)	-0.172 (0.151)	-0.001 (0.036)	0.016 (0.028)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,305	1,042
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household holds a mortgage using a property other than its main residence as collateral. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses. Full estimates reported in the appendix.
* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

A key feature of the HFCS is the collection of information about the underlying purpose of the mortgage. Among the nine options available to survey respondents — which are illustrated in Table A.1 — I evaluate whether households use the inherited property as collateral to purchase additional real estate. This represents a direct test of the investment mechanism discussed in Section 2.

The results show similar cross-country differences as those observed in the previous model. In particular, German households rapidly seize the property shock as an opportunity to expand their housing portfolio. In fact, within two years since receiving a dwelling, the probability of having a mortgage collateralized by other property to purchase additional real estate increases by approximately 12 percentage points. By contrast, neither land inheritance nor the results from the Spanish models report statistically significant results.

Table 4 Inheritance Timing and Mortgages for Additional Real Estate: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	0.123** (0.057)	-0.017 (0.069)	0.006 (0.031)	-0.171 (0.107)
Received 3–7 years ago	0.021 (0.055)	0.252 (0.216)	0.024 (0.031)	-0.054 (0.067)
Received 8+ years ago	0.051 (0.036)	-0.153 (0.138)	-0.027 (0.024)	0.040 (0.038)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,302	1,040
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household uses a mortgage using other property as collateral to finance the acquisition of additional real estate. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses. Full estimates reported in the appendix.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

These patterns may reflect cross-country differences in the role of housing within household portfolios. In Spain, where the housing boom of the early 2000s brought about one of the highest homeownership rates in Europe (Raya 2018; Guinea et al. 2023), property transfers may be less relevant for additional leveraged investments and more significant for other purposes, such as earning income from renting. On the other end, in Germany, where the percentage of families owning the house they live in is the lowest in Europe (Kofner 2014), collateral increase through property transfers may be a strong determinant for households’ decision to invest in the real estate market.

Overall, the findings suggest that the implications of property transfers may depend strongly on national housing-market structures, highlighting the importance of institution-specific policy responses to prevent intergenerational transfers from further complicating access to sustainable housing. This concern is especially relevant for low-wealth households, which are also less likely to receive an inheritance (Tiefensee and Westermeier 2016; Nolan et al. 2021).

4.3 Income from Real Estate

Another source of divergence between inheritors and non-inheritors comes from the potential gains deriving from the rental market. The expansion of short-term rental (STR) platforms such as Airbnb has reinforced the role of housing as an investment asset and source of income generation rather than solely a consumption good (Cocola-Gant et al. 2025). Driven by high yields and capital gains, asset-rich families are incentivized to participate in the rental market, further straining local housing supply,

with substantial effects on rent prices and housing costs (Garcia-López et al. 2020; Duso et al. 2024).

In this respect, the role of inheritance in shaping households' participation in the rental market has largely been overlooked in the literature. Beyond providing collateral value, inherited real estate can be used to generate new income from renting, potentially widening wealth disparities between asset-rich and asset-poor households.

Table 5 shows the results of the fixed-effects models analyzing this relationship. Interestingly, receiving a dwelling or land in Germany is not associated with having earned rental income in the past year. By contrast, Spanish households are more likely to derive rental income from inherited dwellings. The coefficients become statistically significant 3 to 7 years after receiving the dwelling, as the probability of having rental income increases by nearly 13 percentage points. The effects are persistent in the long term, revealing how property inheritance is effectively translated into a consistent revenue stream.

Table 5 Inheritance Timing and Rental Income: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	-0.009 (0.051)	-0.221 (0.184)	0.042 (0.069)	0.289 (0.238)
Received 3–7 years ago	-0.060 (0.056)	-0.156 (0.146)	0.127** (0.051)	-0.012 (0.042)
Received 8+ years ago	0.009 (0.053)	-0.304 (0.212)	0.100* (0.052)	0.066 (0.055)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,305	1,042
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household receives rental income. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses. Full estimates reported in the appendix.
* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

These findings may once again reflect cross-country structural differences in the real estate market. One possible explanation is that, in Germany, where strict regulations and rent caps try to limit the negative effects of STRs (Thomschke 2019; Breidenbach et al. 2022), households may have fewer incentives to enter the rental market. In addition, broad availability of social housing for households up to the median income level contributes to one of the highest shares of long-term renting in Europe (Kofner 2014; Kaas et al. 2021), which may reduce the relative importance of small-scale private rental investment.

In contrast, as the top EU destination for international guests, short-stay accommodations represent a major source of wealth in Spain, where the tourism sector contributed 6% in total gross value added in 2022, compared to 2.6% for Germany⁹. Accordingly, inherited property may represent an especially valuable source of rental income in Spain, where homeownership rates are among the highest in Europe and tourism demand is substantial.

5 Conclusions

While in most OECD countries housing represents the largest component of households' portfolios (Causa et al. 2019) and a historical determinant of lower overall wealth inequality (Kaas et al. 2015; Pfeffer and Waitkus 2021; Darvas et al. 2025), rising house prices, limited social housing, and stringent regulations are making homeownership increasingly unaffordable for young and low-wealth households (Licchetta et al. 2025). These developments are threatening housing's equalizing role, and raising concerns about a growing wealth divide between homeowners and renters (Hick et al. 2024; Balestra et al. 2025).

Despite several studies document the importance of parental wealth and family background in accessing housing (Mulder et al. 2015; Blanden et al. 2023; Daysal et al. 2023), fewer studies analyze the investment responses associated with the inheritance of real estate. This is particularly relevant in a context where the richest 10% of households in OECD countries own roughly 69% of secondary properties (Causa et al. 2019), making the analysis of the related transfers a pressing societal issue.

This paper fills this gap by providing the first systematic analysis of households' investment responses associated with real estate inheritance in two European countries, namely, Germany and Spain. By leveraging the longitudinal component of the Household Finance and Consumption Survey (HFCS) and employing linear fixed-effects models, the results show that households' response strongly depends on the underlying structure of the housing market.

In Germany, where speculative investment in residential real estate has historically been more limited (Kofner 2014; Guinea et al. 2023), households leverage the inherited property as collateral to purchase additional real estate. The effects are statistically significant within two years after receiving the property, and correspond to an increase of about 12.3 percentage points in the probability of having this type of mortgage. In contrast, in Spain, where the housing boom and bust of the early 2000s led to the highest foreclosure rate in Europe (Raya 2018), this effect does not materialize. This suggests that the role of property inheritance in shaping household investment behavior may differ according to the initial distribution of housing ownership. In fact, where the availability of secondary property is high, and the demand for short-stay accommodations is sustained, inheriting households may also use the property windfall as an additional source of revenue by renting the estate. This is particularly the case in Spain, where the homeownership rate is one of the highest in Europe, and tourism represents a comparatively large proportion of GDP.

⁹Eurostat: Tourism statistics. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/index.php?title=Tourism_statistics. Accessed 05 May 2026.

The results indicate that households inheriting a dwelling in Spain are associated with entering the rental market between 3 to 7 years after receiving the property. The probability of earning rental income increases by around 12.7 percentage points upon inheriting a dwelling, and is persistent in the long term (e.g., over 8 years after inheritance), suggesting non-transitory additional gains. In contrast, German models do not show comparable results. This may reflect stricter regulations and recent attempts at curbing the expansion of STRs in major German cities (Thomschke 2019; Breidenbach et al. 2022), which may disincentivize private citizens from entering the market.

Overall, the findings paint a concerning picture for the sustainability of the housing market and the reduction of wealth disparities. First, as shown for German households, property transfers enable additional investments in real estate by relaxing credit constraints through collateral. Given that wealthy households are both more likely to inherit and to receive transfers of larger value (Tiefensee and Westermeier 2016; Nolan et al. 2021), the collateralization of the inherited property may contribute to higher asset concentration and reinforce existing disparities in housing access.

In addition, in areas with strong tourism demand, inherited properties may increasingly be used as rental assets, potentially reducing housing availability for long-term residents (Garcia Teruel 2017; Duso et al. 2024). This may worsen the current housing affordability crisis experienced today in many urban centers, where young people and low-wealth households are forced to spend more than 40% of their income on rent (Licchetta et al. 2025).

Albeit limited in its extendability due to the lack of panel weights, this work represents a relevant stepping stone for future analyses of inheritance and the housing market. By linking the literature of intergenerational transfers and housing wealth, this paper expands the traditional scope of inheritance studies, and speaks to ongoing debates regarding affordability and social justice. Ultimately, the findings resonate with discussions regarding the impact of STR platforms on housing stocks (Bei and Celata 2023; Colomb 2025). By showing that real estate inheritance facilitates the generation of rental income, the paper opens the door to future work that links intergenerational transfers to STR participation more directly, potentially revealing insights about who is able to benefit from the growing monetization of housing services and why.

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Declarations

- Funding: This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.
- Conflict of interest: The author has no competing interests to declare that are relevant to the content of this article.
- Ethics approval and consent to participate: ‘Not applicable’.

- Consent for publication: ‘Not applicable’.
- Data availability: The dataset analyzed during the current study is available to researchers upon request at https://www.ecb.europa.eu/stats/ecb_surveys/hfcs/html/index.en.html.
- Materials and Code availability: All materials and code used in the analysis are available upon request to the author.
- Author contribution: The author confirms the sole responsibility for the conception of the study, performed analysis and manuscript preparation.

Appendix A Additional Tables

Table A.1 HFCS variable definitions

Analysis variable	Survey question / definition	Coding
Real estate outcomes		
Owns other properties	“Apart from your house/apartment, do you/does your household own any (other) properties, such as houses, apartments, garages, offices, hotels, other commercial buildings, farms, land, etc.?” Includes properties in the survey country and abroad. ^a	1=Yes, 0=No
Mortgage on other property	“Are there currently any outstanding mortgages or loans that use this property as collateral?” (asked for each other property).	1=Yes, 0=No
Mortgage on other property: purpose of the loan	“When you/your household first took out this mortgage, what was the purpose for which the money was used?” Set of up to four items (a–d), with (a) main purpose. Category 2 corresponds to “To purchase other real estate.”	1–9 categories ^b
Has rental income	“Did you/your household receive any income from renting real estate in the last 12 months / the last calendar year?”	1=Yes, 0=No
Income and baseline wealth controls		
Wealth quintile (1–5)	Household position in the national net wealth distribution, computed within country.	1–5
Gross household income, equivalised	Total gross annual household income aggregate, equalised using the modified OECD equivalence scale.	Numeric (EUR)
Demographic controls (reference person, Canberra definition)		
Nr. economically active members	The economically active population comprises all persons of either sex who furnish the supply of labour for the production of goods and services during a specified time-reference period.	Numeric
Nr. dependent children	Dependent children defined as all persons aged 0–15 and person aged 16–24 not at work and living with a parent.	Numeric
Age of reference person	Age of the household reference person.	Numeric (years)
Marital status	“What is X’s (your) marital status?”	Ordered categories ^c
Labour status	Main labour status of the reference person.	Ordered categories ^d
Gender	Gender of the reference person.	0=Male, 1=Female
Education	Highest educational attainment of the reference person (Canberra definition).	Ordered categories ^e
Inheritance receipt and characteristics		
Any inheritance / substantial gift	“Have you/has any member of the household ever received an inheritance or a substantial gift, including money or any other assets (from someone not part of your current household)?”	1=Yes, 0=No
Year of receipt	“In what year did you/your household receive it?” (asked for up to three most important inheritances).	Numeric (year)
Type of assets received	“What kinds of assets were received?” Multiple answers allowed; records whether each asset category was included.	Binary indicators ^f

Notes: The household reference person follows the UN/Canberra definition. Questions referring to inheritances are asked for up to the three most important gifts or inheritances reported by the household.

^a Business properties are included only if fully or partially owned directly by the household; properties owned by a business are excluded.

^b Purpose categories: (1) purchase/construct this property; (2) purchase other real estate; (3) refurbish/renovate residence; (4) vehicle/transport; (5) finance business/professional activity; (6) consolidate/refinance debts; (7) education; (8) living expenses/other purchases; (9) other.

^c Marital status coding: 1=Single, 2=Married, 3=Consensual union, 4=Widowed, 5=Divorced

^d Labour status coding: 1=Employee, 2=Self-employed, 3=Unemployed, 4=Retired, 5=Other

^e Education coding: 0=Early childhood/no education; 1=Primary or no formal education; 2=Lower secondary; 3=Upper secondary; 4=Post-secondary non-tertiary; 5=Short-cycle tertiary; 6=Bachelor or equivalent.

^f Asset categories recorded through binary indicators (1=Yes, 2=No): money; dwelling; use of a dwelling (usufruct or similar); land; business; securities or shares; jewellery, furniture, artwork; life insurance; car/vehicle; other assets.

Table A.2 Inheritance Timing and Ownership of Other Property: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	0.291*** (0.091)	0.098 (0.094)	0.314*** (0.069)	0.280** (0.141)
Received 3–7 years ago	0.066 (0.075)	0.167 (0.266)	0.361*** (0.067)	0.479*** (0.145)
Received 8+ years ago	0.095* (0.054)	-0.067 (0.055)	0.279*** (0.054)	0.453*** (0.110)
<i>Control variables</i>				
Nr. economically active members	0.013 (0.013)	0.016 (0.013)	0.026 (0.018)	0.031 (0.021)
Nr. dependent children	-0.010 (0.018)	-0.005 (0.020)	0.053** (0.023)	0.050** (0.025)
Household income	0.026*** (0.008)	0.024*** (0.008)	0.023*** (0.006)	0.020** (0.009)
Age	0.016*** (0.006)	0.007 (0.006)	0.007 (0.010)	0.005 (0.011)
Age squared	-0.0001** (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0000 (0.0001)
Tertiary education	0.007 (0.022)	0.005 (0.023)	0.043 (0.037)	0.068 (0.048)
Employed	-0.006 (0.026)	-0.002 (0.027)	-0.056 (0.039)	-0.020 (0.044)
Female	-0.001 (0.023)	0.001 (0.024)	-0.009 (0.036)	-0.003 (0.037)
Married	0.106*** (0.034)	0.108*** (0.033)	0.026 (0.049)	0.043 (0.056)
<i>Year fixed effects</i>				
2014	-0.008 (0.015)	0.001 (0.016)	0.043* (0.025)	0.027 (0.028)
2017	0.017 (0.018)	0.034* (0.018)	0.093*** (0.030)	0.058* (0.034)
2020	-0.058** (0.024)	-0.038 (0.025)	0.131*** (0.040)	0.074 (0.045)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,305	1,042
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household owns property other than its main residence. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.3 Inheritance Timing and Mortgages on Other Properties: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	0.140** (0.063)	-0.020 (0.070)	-0.038 (0.062)	-0.096 (0.097)
Received 3–7 years ago	0.063 (0.090)	0.244 (0.216)	0.060 (0.045)	0.105 (0.098)
Received 8+ years ago	0.083* (0.046)	-0.172 (0.151)	-0.001 (0.036)	0.016 (0.028)
<i>Control variables</i>				
Nr. economically active members	0.004 (0.009)	-0.002 (0.009)	0.031** (0.015)	0.033** (0.017)
Nr. dependent children	-0.004 (0.015)	-0.005 (0.015)	0.030 (0.022)	0.017 (0.022)
Wealth quintile	0.018* (0.010)	0.016 (0.010)	0.015 (0.018)	0.032* (0.019)
Household income	0.013** (0.006)	0.008 (0.005)	0.007** (0.003)	0.011* (0.006)
Age	0.006 (0.004)	0.003 (0.004)	0.014** (0.006)	0.016** (0.007)
Age squared	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0002*** (0.0001)	-0.0002** (0.0001)
Tertiary education	0.003 (0.016)	0.003 (0.015)	-0.025 (0.025)	-0.010 (0.028)
Employed	0.025 (0.021)	0.012 (0.021)	-0.043* (0.025)	-0.006 (0.029)
Female	-0.011 (0.017)	-0.018 (0.018)	0.010 (0.026)	0.003 (0.026)
Married	-0.012 (0.024)	-0.014 (0.024)	-0.025 (0.042)	-0.054 (0.051)
<i>Year fixed effects</i>				
2014	-0.003 (0.011)	0.005 (0.012)	0.029 (0.018)	0.032 (0.021)
2017	0.002 (0.014)	0.016 (0.015)	0.008 (0.023)	0.000 (0.026)
2020	-0.048*** (0.017)	-0.030* (0.016)	0.034 (0.028)	0.021 (0.033)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,305	1,042
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household holds a mortgage using a property other than its main residence as collateral. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.4 Inheritance Timing and Mortgages for Additional Real Estate: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	0.123** (0.057)	-0.017 (0.069)	0.006 (0.031)	-0.171 (0.107)
Received 3–7 years ago	0.021 (0.055)	0.252 (0.216)	0.024 (0.031)	-0.054 (0.067)
Received 8+ years ago	0.051 (0.036)	-0.153 (0.138)	-0.027 (0.024)	0.040 (0.038)
<i>Control variables</i>				
Nr. economically active members	0.010 (0.009)	0.002 (0.009)	0.010 (0.012)	0.023** (0.011)
Nr. dependent children	0.004 (0.014)	-0.004 (0.014)	-0.000 (0.016)	-0.011 (0.015)
Wealth quintile	0.011 (0.009)	0.015* (0.009)	-0.005 (0.009)	0.002 (0.008)
Household income	0.003 (0.005)	0.005 (0.005)	0.000 (0.002)	-0.001 (0.002)
Age	0.003 (0.003)	-0.001 (0.003)	-0.004 (0.004)	-0.002 (0.004)
Age squared	-0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)
Tertiary education	0.005 (0.015)	0.005 (0.015)	0.002 (0.023)	0.007 (0.028)
Employed	0.031** (0.015)	0.025 (0.016)	-0.002 (0.019)	0.031 (0.021)
Female	0.006 (0.015)	0.003 (0.014)	-0.001 (0.021)	-0.017 (0.024)
Married	0.002 (0.014)	-0.001 (0.017)	-0.030 (0.030)	-0.033 (0.037)
<i>Year fixed effects</i>				
2014	-0.008 (0.010)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.099*** (0.017)	-0.099*** (0.019)
2017	0.018 (0.011)	0.021* (0.012)	-0.095*** (0.017)	-0.097*** (0.020)
2020	-0.016 (0.013)	-0.014 (0.014)	-0.092*** (0.019)	-0.094*** (0.022)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,302	1,040
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household uses a mortgage using other property as collateral to finance the acquisition of additional real estate. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A.5 Inheritance Timing and Rental Income: Dwelling vs Land

	Germany		Spain	
	Dwelling	Land	Dwelling	Land
<i>Timing since inheritance</i>				
Received 0–2 years ago	-0.009 (0.051)	-0.221 (0.184)	0.042 (0.069)	0.289 (0.238)
Received 3–7 years ago	-0.060 (0.056)	-0.156 (0.146)	0.127** (0.051)	-0.012 (0.042)
Received 8+ years ago	0.009 (0.053)	-0.304 (0.212)	0.100* (0.052)	0.066 (0.055)
<i>Control variables</i>				
Nr. economically active members	0.000 (0.011)	0.010 (0.012)	0.010 (0.010)	0.003 (0.009)
Nr. dependent children	-0.014 (0.018)	-0.003 (0.020)	0.022* (0.013)	0.002 (0.011)
Wealth quintile	0.049*** (0.011)	0.036*** (0.011)	0.015 (0.012)	0.007 (0.009)
Household income (excl. rents)	-0.005 (0.005)	-0.007 (0.005)	-0.009 (0.006)	-0.011 (0.008)
Age	0.011** (0.005)	0.010** (0.005)	-0.000 (0.005)	0.004 (0.005)
Age squared	-0.0001** (0.0000)	-0.0001* (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
Tertiary education	0.040* (0.024)	0.042* (0.024)	-0.011 (0.026)	0.020 (0.018)
Employed	-0.021 (0.022)	-0.028 (0.024)	-0.006 (0.024)	-0.025 (0.020)
Female	0.015 (0.022)	0.019 (0.024)	-0.022 (0.019)	-0.009 (0.016)
Married	0.072** (0.033)	0.076** (0.032)	-0.043 (0.032)	-0.036 (0.031)
<i>Year fixed effects</i>				
2014	0.002 (0.012)	0.005 (0.012)	0.035* (0.019)	0.017 (0.017)
2017	0.016 (0.015)	0.028* (0.016)	0.043** (0.021)	0.042** (0.020)
2020	-0.009 (0.021)	0.005 (0.022)	0.070*** (0.022)	0.042* (0.023)
Observations	2,430	2,122	1,305	1,042
Household FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Household fixed-effects linear probability models. The dependent variable is an indicator equal to 1 if the household receives rental income. Coefficients capture the effect of receiving an inheritance in the indicated time window. Columns distinguish inheritance of dwellings and land. Standard errors clustered at the household level in parentheses.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

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